DOCUMENT TEMPLATE

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SHARING INFORMATION CLEARLY

A document template for correspondence, briefings and reports

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INTRODUCTION AND CONTEXT

This template provides a consistent way to share information in a clear, readable document. It combines an illustrated cover with a contents page and spacious pages for the main text.

Begin each new document by explaining its subject, why you are sharing it and what the reader needs to understand or do. Include the background needed to make sense of the detail that follows.

Purpose and scope

State the purpose in a short opening paragraph. Explain what the document covers and include any limits that materially affect the reader. Name the intended audience where that helps establish the context.

The main message

After the context, give the main finding, proposal or request. Longer documents can include a short summary here before moving into the supporting explanation.

The structure is flexible. A briefing may explain a situation and the next decision; a proposal may set out an approach and its costs; a personal document may simply share information with someone.

MAIN CONTENT

Organise the main text into sections that suit the subject. Use short, connected paragraphs to explain the evidence, reasoning and implications. Let the content determine the length rather than filling a fixed number of pages.

Clear sections

Use descriptive headings and a shallow hierarchy. Keep each heading with the paragraph that follows it, and use lists only when they make a sequence or a set of related points easier to read.

Tables and supporting material

Use a table when the reader needs to compare the same attributes across several items. Keep longer explanations in prose and place captions close to their tables or images.

Component	Purpose
Paragraphs	Explain the situation, reasoning and implications.
Tables	Compare options, figures or repeated records.
Images and charts	Show relevant evidence or explain a relationship.

Table 1 Examples of content components

A useful detail should help the reader understand the subject or make a decision.

CLOSING SECTIONS

End in a way that matches the purpose of the document. An informational note may need only a short closing paragraph. A proposal or decision paper may need recommendations and next steps.

Recommendations and next steps

Explain what should happen and why. Include responsibilities, dates and commitments only when they are known. Do not add an action section to a document that is simply sharing information.

References

Where claims depend on source material, include descriptive links near the relevant text or a short reference list. Name supporting documents clearly so the reader can find the evidence.

Appendices

Place detailed calculations, technical information or lengthy supporting material in appendices when they would interrupt the main explanation. The main document should remain understandable on its own.

Remove any example sections that the finished document does not need. Replace the cover title, subtitle, author and date, then refresh the contents and page numbers before sharing the PDF.

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